Q-PUEBLO / REPORT 1

Can Pueblo County balance its budget and protect public services?

The 2027 plan closes a General Fund gap. Lasting recovery still depends on savings, financing and service results.

Updated November 10, 2026 | Publication review copy

Pueblo County government. This is separate from the City of Pueblo budget.

The answer

The County's proposal would balance the General Fund through spending reductions, with a stated $1.265 million annual surplus. That is a plan, not money already saved. Other funds still show negative projected balances, and the starting General Fund balance assumes an asset sale and financing. The available records do not yet establish a durable recovery or unchanged public services.

A proposed balanced General Fund is a meaningful step. It is not yet proof of financial recovery across County services.

General Fund item	Amount	How to read it
Revenue and other funding sources	$122,666,601	Proposed for 2027
Spending before the reduction plan	$131,213,309	Starting departmental budgets
Proposed spending reductions	$9,811,472	Targets, not achieved savings
Spending after those reductions	$121,401,837	Proposed for 2027
County's stated annual surplus	$1,264,763	An annual result, not cash or total reserves

Sources: S1. CALC means Q-Pueblo calculation.

All 2027 figures are proposals. This report explains reviewed public records; it does not certify actual savings, cash or service levels.

What the records show

1. The proposal closes a real starting gap on paper

The detailed budget book lists the amounts in the table above. Its proposed reductions exceed its stated starting shortfall by about $1.265 million. These are proposed budgets for 2027, not a report of savings already delivered.

The book bases its reduction target on eligible personnel costs, including the associated health allocation. Elected offices may meet their dollar targets in different spending categories. A 15% personnel-based target does not mean every department loses 15% of its total budget or that 15% of staff will be dismissed.

Sources: S1, S2. CALC means Q-Pueblo calculation.

2. The wider financial position remains conditional

The proposal presentation projects the year-end balances shown below. Those are budgetary fund balances, not bank balances or interchangeable pots of unrestricted money. A positive General Fund projection does not clear a negative balance in another fund.

The presentation says its starting General Fund balance uses unaudited 2025 and 2026 projections that include a $7 million asset sale and an anticipated $15 million financing transaction. Their completion and usable net proceeds were not established in this review. They must not be treated as completed cash receipts or reliable recurring revenue.

Sources: S2. CALC means Q-Pueblo calculation.

Fund	2027 projected ending balance	Meaning
General Fund	$2.16 million	Positive, but conditional and unaudited
Road and Bridge	-$5.10 million	A negative projected budgetary balance
Human Services	-$0.50 million	A separate negative projected balance

3. The underlying pressures connect revenue, facilities and services

The County's financial outlook describes declining marijuana-tax receipts, higher insurance and health-related costs, continuing debt payments and growing maintenance demands. Some totals cover several funds; some recent results are unaudited. Those figures do not all measure the General Fund or the same period.

A building or financing decision creates costs after construction. A useful recovery test therefore follows the full chain: construction commitment, financing payment, operating cost, maintenance requirement and service outcome. A lower capital budget can reflect projects ending; it does not automatically measure a reduction in everyday services.

Sources: S1, S2, S3. CALC means Q-Pueblo calculation.

Qified insight

The connected picture

Qified means bringing evidence together to explain connections, consequences and useful choices.

What changes when we connect the evidence?

The question is larger than whether one column balances. Test the operating plan, starting resources, payment deadlines, other funds and the services people actually receive together. A strong result in one can hide a problem in another.

Who could feel the effects?

Residents and businesses rely on public safety, road maintenance, permits and family services. Staff, contractors and community partners may carry extra work when a budget changes. These are pathways to investigate, not documented service cuts in this report. Use aggregate waits, workload and service coverage; keep personal case files private.

Where could costs move?

A saving for one office can become overtime, a repair bill, a longer wait or extra work for another provider. For example, postponing maintenance could reduce this year's spending while increasing later repair or service disruption. That is a risk to test, not an observed outcome established here.

Which choices deserve comparison?

Compare an across-the-board dollar target with targeted changes tied to workload, contracts and service obligations. Shared transactions may remove duplicated work; cuts can also create bottlenecks. The County says additional shared-services savings are not included in its proposed result. Do not count them a second time or promise them before a pilot measures cost and quality.

What would a convincing recovery look like?

Recurring operations supported by recurring resources; completed financing identified separately; manageable debt-payment dates; fund-specific reserve progress; and measured service continuity. Proposed policy milestones are not reserves already in place. The book proposes a 10% initial reserve floor and a 16.67% long-term target, with phased rebuilding.

Our recommended next decision

Before treating this as a completed recovery, publish a monthly fund-by-fund bridge from the proposal to actual revenue, spending, usable balances and service results. Start with the General Fund, Road and Bridge, and Human Services. Explain material differences and identify a responsible office and next reporting date.

These are Q-Pueblo analytical judgments and recommendations based on S1-S3. A possible cost shift is not a documented service cut.

Test the plan before calling it recovery

4. Small changes could consume the planned cushion

The stated surplus is about 1.03% of proposed General Fund revenue and other sources. Our scenarios below test that margin; they are illustrations, not County forecasts. A 1% revenue shortfall would leave roughly $38,097 of the planned surplus if every other assumption held. If only 80% of the planned reductions were achieved, the illustrative annual result would be about a $697,531 shortfall.

That sensitivity is a reason for frequent actual-to-budget reporting and early service checks. It is not a prediction that the proposal will fail.

Sources: S1, CALC. CALC means Q-Pueblo calculation.

5. The posted documents need a clearer reconciliation

The detailed book uses a $65,409,813 reduction target base; one financial-outlook slide displays $66.96 million. Those are different denominators. We use the book's detailed calculation and ask the County to identify the controlling version and explain the difference.

Whole-dollar arithmetic also differs by $1 from the book's stated shortfall and surplus. Revenue less proposed spending is $1,264,764; the book states $1,264,763. Its rounded presentation figures have additional small differences. We retain the County's stated surplus for our scenarios. The dollar difference does not change this assessment, but the underlying schedule should reconcile before adoption.

Sources: S1, S2, S3, CALC. CALC means Q-Pueblo calculation.

Illustration	Annual result
Proposal as stated	$1,264,763 surplus
Revenue 1% below plan; full reductions	$38,097 surplus
Only 80% of reductions; revenue as planned	$697,531 shortfall

Reproduce the stress tests

Illustrative annual result = stated surplus - (proposed revenue x revenue shortfall) - (planned reductions x undelivered share). Percentages must be expressed as decimals. Every other assumption is unchanged. These are not forecasts or cash projections.

Example: $1,264,763 - ($122,666,601 x 0.01) = $38,096.99. Example: $1,264,763 - ($9,811,472 x 0.20) = -$697,531.40.

What could point in a different direction?

The proposal itself is evidence that the County is planning a response; a projected negative fund balance alone does not establish insolvency or misconduct. Spending reductions may be achieved through contracts, vacancies or process changes rather than a proportional loss of service. The alternatives cannot be resolved without actual spending, implementation and service records.

Follow the money and the service

Connected issue	What to connect	Evidence to check
Jail and public safety	Separate construction and financing from recurring staffing, medical and overtime costs.	Compare cost, staffing coverage and service obligations for the same period.
Roads and infrastructure	A negative projected Road and Bridge balance cannot be cured by assuming all County balances are transferable.	Show fund-specific obligations, maintenance needs and the authorized funding plan.
Family and health services	A budget change may move work or waiting time to partner organizations or households.	Check aggregate caseload, response time and referral completion; do not publish case identities.
Reserves and future budgets	One-time proceeds can help a transition but do not automatically sustain next year's operating costs.	Separate recurring sources, one-time proceeds, restrictions and future debt payments.

Check	Measure	When
Financial delivery	Actual recurring revenue, actual spending and achieved reductions	Monthly, by fund and department
Payment readiness	Cash identified for each obligation and confirmation of receipt	Before each contractual due date
Reserve progress	Eligible usable balance against the adopted policy denominator	Quarterly; distinguish restrictions
Service continuity	Waits, coverage, closures and delayed maintenance	Monthly, with a prior-period comparison
Corrections	Explained differences between source documents and updated schedules	Each budget revision

Q-Pueblo recommended measures. This scorecard is not represented as an existing County reporting system.

Your next steps

The posted calendar lists December 10, 2026 for a public hearing to adopt the 2027 budget. Confirm the agenda, time, location and any changes through the Board's official meeting portal or office before attending.

Sources: S4, S7. CALC means Q-Pueblo calculation.

Inspect the proposal and presentations

Open the detailed book and the presentation. Match the fund, year and before/after-reduction column. See the book sections named in the source ledger.

https://pueblocounty.gov/budget-and-finance-department/2027-budget

Ask Budget and Finance

Call (719) 583-6012. Refer to the document title and the questions below. This report has not submitted a request.

https://pueblocounty.gov/budget-and-finance/contact-budget-and-finance

Confirm the public meeting

Use Retrieve BOCC Meeting Documents for the actual agenda. Board office: 719-583-6000. The calendar alone does not establish the hearing time or participation procedure.

https://www.pueblocounty.gov/board-county-commissioners/board-county-commissioners

Find the public-records process

Check the County's current policy and custodian instructions before submitting. Ask about any fees first. The questions here are an unsent draft.

https://www.pueblocounty.gov/board-county-commissioners/open-records-policy

Compare with audited annual reports

Confirm the year and auditor's report. A historical audited result is not a current 2026 cash position.

https://pueblocounty.gov/budget-and-finance-department/annual-comprehensive-financial-report-acfr

Questions you can take to the County

Unsent draft. No message or public-records request has been submitted.

1. Please provide the current 2027 proposal and a reconciliation to the presentation, including the personnel reduction denominator and the final spending targets by office.

2. Please provide the latest actual-to-budget report and year-end forecast for the General Fund, Road and Bridge, and Human Services, with restrictions, commitments and transfers identified.

3. What is the status of the assumed asset sale and financing, their usable net proceeds, restrictions, debt costs and payment dates?

4. Which service measures will show whether the reductions affect waiting times, public safety coverage, road maintenance or family-service access, and when will those results be published?

5. Which reserve policy has been formally adopted, what spending denominator does it use, and how will annual contributions be reported?

Limits, sources and updates

What we still cannot confirm

- The final adopted 2027 budget, appropriation and any later amendments. The budget page's adopted-budget heading had no linked document at this check.

- Current audited 2025 results and a reconciled 2026 year-end forecast. The annual-report page checked here listed reports through 2024; that does not prove no newer audit exists elsewhere.

- Whether the assumed asset sale and financing have closed, the net proceeds available to each fund and the resulting payment schedule.

- The exact source of the differing reduction bases, whole-dollar differences and all presentation-to-book changes.

- Achieved savings and service-level effects, including workload or costs shifted to other organizations.

How we did the work

We independently retrieved official public records for this report, cross-checked the proposal book against two County presentations, visually inspected key slide tables and recalculated the financial examples. No private chat, Drive archive or recovered private text is quoted or used as evidence. All observations use November 10, 2026 in America/Denver. This is a source-attributed explanatory analysis, not an audit, legal opinion or certification of future service levels.

S1 | 2027 Preliminary Proposed Budget book

2027 proposal, hosted in October 2026; exact issue date not supplied. First 24 PDF pages retrieved. Sections: Budget message; Budget basis; Reducing spending; Financial Stabilization Policy; Where General Fund resources come from; General Fund budget calculation. Not all 115 PDF pages reviewed.

https://pueblocounty.gov/sites/default/files/2026-10/Final%20Pueblo%20County%202027%20Preliminary%20Budget%20Book--2.pdf

S2 | 2027 Proposed Budget Presentation

October 2026 proposal meeting. All 9 pages retrieved; financial tables on PDF pages 2-9. General Fund, fund-balance assumptions and department targets. Key tables visually inspected.

https://pueblocounty.gov/sites/default/files/2026-10/2027%20Proposed%20Budget%20SB.pdf

S3 | 2027 Financial Outlook Presentation

Hosted in October 2026; exact issue date not supplied. All 15 pages retrieved. Financial pressures, proposed reserve policy, reduction base, debt controls and shared-services assumptions. Reduction slide visually inspected.

https://pueblocounty.gov/sites/default/files/2026-10/2027%20Financial%20Update%20Final.pdf

S4 | 2027 Budget Meeting Calendar

2026 planning calendar. One page. December 10 hearing date is scheduled, subject to the final agenda.

https://pueblocounty.gov/sites/default/files/2026-10/2027%20Budget%20Meeting%20Calendar.pdf

S5 | County 2027 budget page

Page checked November 10, 2026. Document directory and proposal/adopted-budget headings; absence of a link does not prove absence of an action elsewhere.

https://pueblocounty.gov/budget-and-finance-department/2027-budget

S6 | Budget and Finance contact page

Page checked November 10, 2026. Published department contact, not a guarantee of response time.

https://pueblocounty.gov/budget-and-finance/contact-budget-and-finance

S7 | Board of County Commissioners and open-records pages

Page checked November 10, 2026. Board role, phone and official meeting-document route. Open-records process linked separately in Resources.

https://www.pueblocounty.gov/board-county-commissioners/board-county-commissioners

S8 | Annual Comprehensive Financial Report directory

Page checked November 10, 2026. Listing through 2024 at retrieval. No claim that all possible 2025 audit locations were searched.

https://pueblocounty.gov/budget-and-finance-department/annual-comprehensive-financial-report-acfr

Updates and corrections

Reopen on an adopted budget, a corrected schedule, audited results, completed financing, actual savings or material service evidence. Preserve this edition and link the replacement. A correction to a dollar figure must also update its calculations and Qified assessment.

Report version 1.0.0. Human publication review remains open.